CONSULTING INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

1. Core Consulting Questions

Q1. What is consulting?
Consulting involves helping organizations solve business problems by analyzing data, identifying inefficiencies, and recommending actionable solutions. Consultants combine business understanding, analytical thinking, and communication skills to deliver measurable impact, such as cost reduction or revenue growth.

Q2. Why do you want to go into consulting?
A strong answer should focus on problem-solving, exposure to diverse industries, and impact. For example: Consulting allows me to work on varied business problems, apply analytical skills to real-world challenges, and directly influence decision-making. The fast-paced environment and learning opportunities align well with my career goals.

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2. Problem-Solving & Case Thinking

Q3. How would you approach solving a business problem? (VERY IMPORTANT)
I would follow a structured approach: first clearly define the problem, then break it into smaller components, identify relevant data, analyze root causes, propose solutions, and finally evaluate impact. This ensures a logical and data-driven solution rather than jumping to conclusions.

Q4. A company's profits are declining. How would you analyze it?
I would break profits into revenue and costs. Then analyze revenue streams such as pricing, volume, and customer segments, and costs such as fixed and variable expenses. By identifying which component is causing the decline, I can suggest targeted solutions like cost optimization or pricing strategy changes.

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3. Data & Analytics-Based Questions

Q5. How do you use data to make decisions?
I would first define the objective, then collect relevant data, clean and preprocess it, perform analysis to identify trends or patterns, and finally translate insights into actionable recommendations. The key is to ensure that decisions are data-driven but also aligned with business context.

Q6. What metrics would you track for a business?
Metrics depend on the business type, but generally include revenue, profit margins, customer acquisition cost, retention rate, and operational efficiency metrics. The focus is on KPIs that directly impact business goals.

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4. Case-Based Questions (VERY IMPORTANT)

Q7. How would you reduce delivery time for a logistics company?
I would analyze the delivery process, identify bottlenecks such as route inefficiencies or warehouse delays, and use optimization techniques like route planning algorithms. Implementing real-time tracking and predictive analytics can further improve efficiency.

Q8. How would you increase sales for an e-commerce company?
I would analyze customer behavior, conversion rates, and product performance. Strategies could include improving user experience, targeted marketing campaigns, personalized recommendations, and optimizing pricing.

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5. Product & Business Thinking

Q9. How would you improve a product?
I would gather user feedback, analyze usage data, identify pain points, and prioritize improvements based on impact and feasibility. Continuous iteration based on user needs is key.

Q10. How would you launch a new product?
The approach involves market research, identifying target customers, defining value proposition, pricing strategy, marketing plan, and measuring success using KPIs.

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6. Supply Chain / O9-Specific Questions

Q11. What is supply chain optimization?
Supply chain optimization involves improving efficiency across procurement, production, and distribution to minimize costs and maximize service levels.

Q12. How would you forecast demand?
Demand forecasting can be done using historical data, seasonality patterns, and predictive models. Combining statistical models with business insights ensures better accuracy.

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7. Communication & Stakeholder Questions

Q13. How do you explain complex data to non-technical stakeholders?
I would simplify insights using visualizations and focus on business impact rather than technical details. The goal is to make the information actionable and easy to understand.

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8. Behavioral + Consulting Mix

Q14. Tell me about a time you solved a problem.
Structure your answer using STAR (Situation, Task, Action, Result). Focus on how you approached the problem, not just the outcome.

Q15. How do you handle ambiguity? (VERY IMPORTANT)
I break down the problem into smaller parts, make reasonable assumptions, and proceed with a structured approach. Regular validation ensures that I stay aligned with the objective.

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9. Analytical Thinking

Q16. Estimate the number of petrol pumps in India. (Guesstimate)
I would break it down using population, number of vehicles, average fuel consumption, and pump capacity. This structured breakdown helps arrive at a reasonable estimate.

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10. Decision-Making Questions

Q17. How do you prioritize tasks?
I prioritize based on impact and urgency, ensuring that high-value tasks are completed first while maintaining efficiency.

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11. Technology + Consulting (IMPORTANT for O9)

Q18. How can technology improve business processes?
Technology enables automation, data-driven decision-making, and improved efficiency. For example, analytics tools can optimize supply chains and reduce costs.

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12. Case Scenario

Q19. A client wants to reduce costs. What will you do?
I would identify major cost drivers, analyze inefficiencies, and suggest optimization strategies such as process automation or vendor renegotiation.

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13. Market Entry Case

Q20. A company wants to enter a new market. How would you approach it?
I would analyze market size, competition, customer demand, and regulatory factors before recommending an entry strategy.

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14. Growth Strategy

Q21. How would you grow a startup?
Growth can be achieved through customer acquisition, product improvement, partnerships, and scaling operations.

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15. Risk Analysis

Q22. What risks should businesses consider?
Risks include market risks, operational risks, financial risks, and technological risks.

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16. Final High-Impact Questions

Q23. What makes a good consultant?
A good consultant has strong problem-solving skills, communication ability, business understanding, and adaptability.

Q24. How do you deal with difficult clients?
I would listen actively, understand their concerns, and provide data-driven solutions while maintaining professionalism.

Q25. What is your biggest strength for consulting?
Answer should highlight analytical thinking, structured approach, and communication.

1. Demand Forecasting Case (MOST IMPORTANT)

Q1. A retail company is facing frequent stockouts and overstock issues. How would you solve this?

Answer:
First, I would clarify the scope—identify which products and regions are most affected. Then I would break the problem into two parts: demand forecasting accuracy and inventory planning.

I would analyze historical sales data, seasonality patterns, promotions, and external factors like holidays. Feature engineering would include trends, lag variables, and promotional impacts. For forecasting, I would start with statistical models like moving averages and then move to advanced models like regression or machine learning models.

On the inventory side, I would optimize reorder points and safety stock using demand variability and lead time. Additionally, integrating real-time data into planning systems would improve responsiveness.

The business impact would be reduced stockouts, lower inventory holding costs, and improved customer satisfaction.

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2. Supply Chain Optimization Case

Q2. A company wants to reduce delivery time across its supply chain. What will you do?

Answer:
I would first map the entire supply chain—from suppliers to warehouses to customers—to identify bottlenecks. Then I would analyze key metrics like transit time, warehouse processing time, and order fulfillment time.

Using data analytics, I would identify delays caused by inefficient routes or inventory misallocation. Solutions could include route optimization algorithms, better warehouse placement, and demand-driven inventory distribution.

Implementing real-time tracking and predictive analytics can further reduce delays. The impact would be faster delivery, improved service levels, and competitive advantage.

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3. Inventory Optimization Case

Q3. A company has excess inventory leading to high costs. How would you reduce it?

Answer:
I would start by segmenting inventory into fast-moving and slow-moving items. Then I would analyze demand variability and lead times.

For slow-moving items, I would recommend reducing reorder quantities and possibly discounting to clear stock. For fast-moving items, maintaining optimal stock levels is important.

Implementing techniques like EOQ (Economic Order Quantity) and safety stock optimization would help. The business impact would be reduced holding costs and improved cash flow.

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4. Pricing Strategy Case

Q4. A company wants to optimize pricing for its products. How would you approach it?

Answer:
I would analyze historical pricing data and demand elasticity to understand how price changes affect sales. Then I would segment customers and products to apply differentiated pricing strategies.

Using regression models or A/B testing, I would identify optimal price points. Dynamic pricing can also be considered for competitive markets.

The goal is to maximize revenue while maintaining customer satisfaction.

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5. Sales Decline Case

Q5. A company's sales have dropped by 20%. How would you investigate?

Answer:
I would break sales into components: price, volume, and customer segments. Then I would analyze trends across regions, products, and time periods.

Possible causes could include increased competition, pricing issues, or reduced demand. Based on findings, solutions may include marketing campaigns, pricing adjustments, or product improvements.

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6. Forecast Accuracy Case

Q6. Forecast accuracy is low. What would you do?

Answer:
I would first measure forecast accuracy using metrics like MAPE. Then I would identify sources of error such as poor data quality or missing variables.

Improving feature selection, using better models, and incorporating external data can improve accuracy. Continuous monitoring and model retraining are also important.

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7. Warehouse Optimization Case

Q7. A warehouse is inefficient and causing delays. How would you improve it?

Answer:
I would analyze warehouse layout, picking processes, and inventory placement. Using ABC analysis, high-demand items should be placed closer to dispatch areas.

Automation and optimized picking routes can significantly improve efficiency. The result would be faster order fulfillment.

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8. Logistics Cost Reduction Case

Q8. How would you reduce logistics costs?

Answer:
I would analyze transportation routes, shipment sizes, and vendor contracts. Consolidating shipments and optimizing routes can reduce costs.

Negotiating better contracts with vendors and using data-driven planning can further improve efficiency.

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9. Customer Segmentation Case

Q9. How would you segment customers for better targeting?

Answer:
I would use clustering techniques based on purchase behavior, frequency, and demographics. This allows targeted marketing strategies such as premium offers for high-value customers.

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10. Real-Time Dashboard Case

Q10. A client wants a real-time dashboard for supply chain. How would you design it?

Answer:
I would identify key KPIs such as inventory levels, order status, and delivery times. Data pipelines would be set up for real-time updates.

Visualization tools would present insights clearly, enabling quick decision-making.

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11. Demand Spike Case

Q11. Sudden demand spike occurs. How will you handle it?

Answer:
I would analyze the cause—seasonality, promotions, or external events. Then adjust inventory and supply plans dynamically.

Real-time monitoring and flexible supply chains are key.

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12. Vendor Selection Case

Q12. How would you select the best supplier?

Answer:
I would evaluate suppliers based on cost, reliability, quality, and delivery time. A scoring model can help rank suppliers objectively.

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13. Product Launch Case

Q13. How would you forecast demand for a new product?

Answer:
Since historical data is unavailable, I would use analogous products, market research, and pilot launches.

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14. Capacity Planning Case

Q14. How would you plan production capacity?

Answer:
I would forecast demand and align production capacity accordingly, considering constraints like labor and machinery.

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15. End-to-End Case (VERY IMPORTANT)

Q15. Design a complete supply chain solution for a company.

Answer:
I would start with demand forecasting, followed by inventory optimization, production planning, and logistics optimization.

Integrating all these components into a unified platform ensures visibility and efficiency. Continuous monitoring and data-driven adjustments are essential.

PUZZLES

1. 3 Switches and 1 Bulb (VERY POPULAR)

Problem:
You are outside a room with 3 switches. Inside the room is 1 bulb. Only one switch controls the bulb. You can enter the room only once. How do you identify the correct switch?

Solution:
Turn ON switch 1 and leave it ON for a few minutes. Then turn it OFF and turn ON switch 2. Now go inside the room.

- If the bulb is ON → switch 2 is correct
- If the bulb is OFF but warm → switch 1 is correct
- If the bulb is OFF and cold → switch 3 is correct

Concept: Use both light and heat (state + history).

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2. 8 Balls Puzzle

Problem:
You have 8 balls, one is heavier. Find it using a weighing scale in minimum attempts.

Solution:
Divide into 3 groups: 3, 3, 2

- Weigh first 3 vs second 3
- If equal → heavier is in remaining 2 → weigh them
- Else → heavier is in heavier group → pick 2 from it and weigh

Minimum attempts = 2

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3. Two Eggs, 100 Floors

Problem:
Find highest floor from which egg won't break using minimum attempts.

Solution:
Use decreasing intervals:
Start from 14th floor, then 27 (14+13), then 39, etc.
If egg breaks, use second egg linearly below that floor.

Minimum attempts = 14

Concept: Optimize worst-case using decreasing step size.

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4. 100 Doors Puzzle

Problem:
100 doors initially closed. Toggle every i-th door in i-th round. Which doors remain open?

Solution:
Only doors with perfect square numbers remain open (1, 4, 9, 16, …).

Reason:
Only perfect squares have odd number of factors.

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5. Poisoned Bottle Puzzle

Problem:
1000 bottles, 1 poisoned. You have 10 rats. Poison kills in 1 hour. Find bottle in 1 hour.

Solution:
Use binary representation. Assign each bottle a number (1–1000).
Each rat represents a bit position. Feed rats accordingly.
Dead rats indicate binary number of poisoned bottle.

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6. Bridge Crossing Puzzle

Problem:
4 people need to cross bridge with one torch. Times: 1, 2, 5, 10 minutes. Max two at a time.

Solution:
1 & 2 cross → 2 min
1 returns → 1 min
5 & 10 cross → 10 min
2 returns → 2 min
1 & 2 cross → 2 min

Total = 17 minutes

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7. 9 Dots Puzzle

Problem:
Connect 9 dots using 4 straight lines without lifting pen.

Solution:
Extend lines beyond dots (think outside the box).

Concept: Break implicit constraints.

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8. Water Jug Puzzle

Problem:
You have 3L and 5L jugs. Measure exactly 4L.

Solution:
Fill 5L → pour into 3L → 2L left
Empty 3L → transfer 2L
Fill 5L → pour into 3L → 4L remains

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9. Train and Platform Puzzle

Problem:
Two trains moving toward each other. Bird flies between them. Find total distance bird travels.

Solution:
Total distance = bird speed × total time until trains meet

Concept: Avoid overcomplication.

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10. Clock Angle Puzzle

Problem:
Find angle between hour and minute hand at 3:15.

Solution:
Minute hand = 90°
Hour hand = 3×30 + (15/60 × 30) = 97.5°
Angle = 7.5°

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11. Pirate Gold Division

Problem:
5 pirates divide gold with voting rules.

Solution:
Work backward using game theory.
Each pirate ensures majority by offering minimal shares.

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12. Missing Square Puzzle

Problem:
A rearranged triangle seems to lose area.

Solution:
It’s an illusion—the shapes don’t form a true triangle due to slope differences.

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13. Light Bulb Toggle (Infinite Version)

Problem:
Infinite bulbs toggled. Which remain ON?

Solution:
Only perfect squares.

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14. Coin Flip Puzzle

Problem:
100 coins, some heads some tails. Divide into two groups with equal heads.

Solution:
Pick any 50 coins → flip them → both groups have equal heads.

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15. Monty Hall Problem

Problem:
3 doors, 1 prize. Should you switch?

Solution:
Yes, switching gives 2/3 probability of winning.

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16. River Crossing (Wolf, Goat, Cabbage)

Solution:
Take goat → return → take wolf → bring goat back → take cabbage → return → take goat.

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17. Hat Puzzle

Problem:
People guessing hat colors in sequence.

Solution:
Use parity strategy (even/odd count).

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18. Two Rope Puzzle

Problem:
Two ropes burn in 60 min but unevenly. Measure 45 min.

Solution:
Burn rope 1 from both ends + rope 2 from one end.
When rope 1 finishes (30 min), burn other end of rope 2 → finishes in 15 min.
Total = 45 min

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19. Chessboard Domino Puzzle

Problem:
Can you cover chessboard missing 2 opposite corners with dominoes?

Solution:
No, because equal black-white squares condition breaks.

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20. Ants on Triangle

Problem:
3 ants randomly move. Probability no collision?

Solution:
2/8 = 1/4

1. Estimate Number of Petrol Pumps in India

Step 1: Clarify
We estimate petrol pumps serving vehicles in India.

Step 2: Assumptions

- Population ≈ 1.4 billion

- 1 vehicle per 10 people → 140 million vehicles
- Each vehicle refuels once per week

Step 3: Demand Calculation
Weekly fuel demand = 140 million refuels
Daily demand ≈ 20 million refuels

Step 4: Capacity Assumption
1 petrol pump serves ≈ 1000 vehicles/day

Step 5: Final Estimate
Number of petrol pumps = 20M / 1000 = **20,000 pumps**

Sanity Check: Real number ~80K → underestimation due to conservative assumptions.

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2. Estimate Number of Swiggy/Zomato Orders per Day in India

Step 1: Clarify
Estimate daily food delivery orders in India.

Step 2: Assumptions

- Urban population ≈ 30% → 420M
- Active users ≈ 25% → 100M
- Each orders 3 times/month → 0.1 orders/day

Step 3: Calculation
Daily orders = 100M × 0.1 = **10 million orders/day**

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3. Estimate Number of Daily Uber Rides in a City (like Delhi)

Step 1: Population
Delhi ≈ 20 million

Step 2: Assumptions

- 30% use ride-hailing → 6M users
- Each takes 1 ride every 3 days → 0.33 rides/day

Step 3: Calculation
Daily rides = 6M × 0.33 ≈ **2 million rides/day**

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4. Estimate Number of Laptops Sold in India per Year

Step 1: Population segmentation
Students + professionals ≈ 400M

Step 2: Assumptions

- 1 laptop per 5 people → 80M users
- Replacement cycle = 5 years

Step 3: Calculation
Annual sales = 80M / 5 = **16 million laptops/year**

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5. Estimate Number of Haircuts per Day in India

Step 1: Population
1.4B

Step 2: Assumptions

- Avg haircut frequency = once per month

Step 3: Calculation
Monthly = 1.4B
Daily = 1.4B / 30 ≈ **45 million haircuts/day**

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6. Estimate Size of Pizza Market in India

Step 1: Target population
Urban ≈ 400M

Step 2: Assumptions

- 20% consume pizza → 80M
- Avg consumption = 2 pizzas/month

Step 3: Calculation
Monthly demand = 160M pizzas
If avg price = ₹300 → market size ≈ ₹48,000M/month

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7. Estimate Number of ATMs in India

Step 1: Population
1.4B

Step 2: Assumptions

- 1 ATM serves 5000 people

Step 3: Calculation
ATMs = 1.4B / 5000 = **280,000 ATMs**

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8. Estimate Daily Milk Consumption in India

Step 1: Population
1.4B

Step 2: Assumptions

- Avg consumption = 0.5 liters/day

Step 3: Calculation
Total = 700M liters/day

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9. Estimate Number of Schools in India

Step 1: Population segmentation
Students ≈ 30% → 420M

Step 2: Assumptions

- Avg school size = 500 students

Step 3: Calculation
Schools = 420M / 500 = **840,000 schools**

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10. Estimate Number of Cars in India

Step 1: Population
1.4B

Step 2: Assumptions

- 1 car per 20 people

Step 3: Calculation
Cars = 70 million

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11. Estimate Daily Internet Data Usage in India

Step 1: Users
Internet users ≈ 800M

Step 2: Assumptions

- Avg usage = 2 GB/day

Step 3: Calculation
Total = **1600 million GB/day**

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12. Estimate Number of Restaurants in a City

Example: Mumbai

Step 1: Population
20M

Step 2: Assumptions

- 1 restaurant per 1000 people

Step 3: Calculation
Restaurants ≈ **20,000**

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13. Estimate Revenue of a Mall

Step 1: Footfall
50,000 visitors/day

Step 2: Assumptions

- Avg spend = ₹500

Step 3: Calculation
Revenue = ₹25M/day

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14. Estimate Number of Flights per Day in India

Step 1: Travelers
~5M daily

Step 2: Assumptions

- Avg 150 passengers per flight

Step 3: Calculation
Flights ≈ **30,000/day**

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15. Estimate Number of Mobile Phones in India

Step 1: Population
1.4B

Step 2: Assumptions

- 80% penetration

Step 3: Calculation
Phones ≈ **1.1 billion**